



Report Date: March 18, 2026

VanRIMS No.: 08-3000-30

[Submit comments to the Board](#)

TO: Park Board Chair and Commissioners
FROM: General Manager, Board of Parks and Recreation
SUBJECT: Columbia Park Renewal - Concept Plan

RECOMMENDATIONS

- A. THAT the Vancouver Park Board approve the concept plan for the renewal of Columbia Park as described in this report and shown in the appendices;
- B. THAT the Vancouver Park Board approve the use of a portion of Columbia Park for an underground city stormwater detention tank managed by the City's Engineering Department; and
- C. THAT the Vancouver Park Board authorize the General Manager of Parks and Recreation and the City's Engineering Services General Manager to finalize and execute funding and land use agreements for the use of Columbia Park by the Engineering Department for a stormwater detention tank to the satisfaction of the General Manager of Parks & Recreation.

PURPOSE AND SUMMARY

The proposed concept as described in this report is for the renewal of Columbia Park, a 2.78 ha permanent park located in the Oakridge Local Area. The concept is informed by public engagement and aligns with City and Park Board policies including prior Board direction. Staff completed public engagement on the proposed park concept in April 2024 and received favourable feedback.

An integral part of the [Alberta Street Blue Green System and Columbia Park Renewal](#) initiative, the park is a key public benefit and priority for a renewal in response to the population growth occurring in the Cambie Corridor Plan area. This project aims to introduce much needed new and renewed park amenities, while providing an enhanced public realm, improved ecological connectivity, and critical drainage services to the growing neighborhood. This project focuses on integrating park renewal and critical drainage infrastructure concurrently.

The purpose of this report is to share the results of the public engagement process and details of the concept, and to seek a Board decision on the proposed concept plan and use of the park for a community serving underground utility, to advance the project to detailed design and park construction, subject to funding. A decision is necessary at this time to allow integrated and coordinated design work to continue with the City Engineering department, supporting multiple objectives across the broader initiative.

BOARD AUTHORITY / PREVIOUS DECISIONS

As per the [Vancouver Charter](#), the Park Board has exclusive jurisdiction and control over all areas designated as permanent and temporary parks in the City of Vancouver, including any structures, programs and activities, fees, and improvements that occur within those parks. The Vancouver Park Board approves major changes in Vancouver parks including the design and development of parks.

[VanPlay: Strategic Bold Moves & The Playbook – Implementation Plan \(2019\)](#)

On October 9, 2019, the Park Board approved:

- [VanPlay: The Playbook – Implementation Plan](#), which identified 24 Approaches for Action, including initiative P2.1.1 to establish Columbia Park as a primary connector and node in the citywide parks network through its renewal.
- [VanPlay Strategic Bold Moves](#) which includes the move to “Weave the City Together” by initiating the ‘Little Mountain to Big River’ (Refer to Appendix D) green network vision and advancing long term habitat connectivity, rainwater integration, and access to nature. The renewal also supports 2040 Asset Targets through universally accessible play features and continuous accessible pathways.

[VanPlay Implementation – One Water Initiatives](#): On February 10, 2020 Park Board received a staff report and endorsed coordination with the [City’s Rain City and Blue-Green Systems initiatives](#) including exploration of integrating rainwater management in Columbia Park as part of broader One Water initiative.

The renewal of Columbia Park is also aligned with several other adopted Park Board and City policy directions:

[Assessment of Playspaces Report](#) (2015): Based on the inventory and assessment of the 159 Park Board - maintained play spaces. The park’s playground was ranked as a Level 2 replacement priority, the second highest-need category, supporting its renewal.

[Biodiversity Strategy](#) (2016): This strategy aims to increase the quantity and quality of natural areas across Vancouver. Renewal of Columbia Park will support local habitat, ecological function and connectivity, and access to nature in alignment with these objectives.

[Sports Field Strategy](#) (2024): The Board-endorsed strategy outlines a 10year plan for equitable renewal and expansion of sports fields citywide. This project advances the strategy by delivering a new synthetic turf field to increase year-round capacity, support equitable access, and meet demand for high-quality, multiuse sport amenities.

[Urban Forest Strategy](#) (Updated 2025): Policy and operational guidelines to enhance the urban forest on private lands, streets, and parks. Columbia Park currently has a tree canopy of approximately 5%; the renewal aims to significantly increase canopy cover in alignment with the strategy’s goals.

[Cambie Corridor Plan](#) & [Public Realm Plan](#) (2018)

[Rain City Strategy](#) (2019)

[Climate Change Adaptation Strategy](#) (2024)

[Transportation 2040](#) (2012)

[The Vancouver Plan](#) (2022)

In 2024, new Provincial legislation was enacted requiring select municipalities to designate Transit-Oriented Development (TOD) Areas within an 800-metre radius of transit hubs. [The Oakridge-41st Avenue Transit Station was one of 52 TOD Areas](#) designated for immediate effect. This project falls largely within the scope of the new legislative framework.

CONTEXT AND BACKGROUND

Neighbourhood Context

Columbia Park is located within the Oakridge local area and the Oakridge Municipal Town Centre (Oakridge MTC), which is centred around the Oakridge-41st Canada Line Station and Oakridge Centre redevelopment (Refer to Appendix E Project Area). MTCs are regionally significant urban centres that serve as activity hubs to accommodate a range of jobs, retail services, cultural programming and public spaces along with a variety of housing options.

The Cambie Corridor and Oakridge area is one of the largest growth areas in the city. While the current population is approximately 13,000, it is expected to increase by over 45,000 new residents within the next 15 years.

Significant changes to density and built form are anticipated around the project area. Currently, the adjacent area is predominantly single-family housing, with higher density near W 41st Avenue and some new multi-story residential buildings under construction nearby.

Existing Park Conditions

Columbia Park is an aging neighbourhood park with facilities that reflect its original development in the 1950's and no longer meet current standards or community needs (Refer to Appendix B, Figure 4). Current amenities include:

- Playground (Beyond expected lifespan and compliance)
- Two unirrigated Class C softball fields overlapping with 2 mini-soccer / Ultimate fields
- 1 Wading pool (inoperative for over a decade)
- A small cluster of mature trees along central-west edge
- 1 Portland Loo (constructed 2024)

Project Context

The renewal of Columbia Park is a critical component of a collaborative strategy, advancing the goals outlined in City and Park board policies by:

- Addressing aging amenities through park enhancements that meet evolving community needs.
- Contributing to a connected blue-green corridor that enhances ecological and recreational connectivity between Columbia Park and Queen Elizabeth Park.
- Responding to drainage and sewer servicing needs to support the neighbourhood's growth and climate resilience, while ensuring that underground infrastructure is carefully integrated with park amenities.

City of Vancouver Engineering Services Initiatives

To support the population growth in the Oakridge MTC Engineering Services is leading critical stormwater and sewer infrastructure upgrades in the area. Upgrades were limited by downstream Metro Vancouver regional infrastructure capacity (Metro Vancouver has no plans to upgrade its trunk sewer which is constraining flow), insufficient space in the right-of-way, grading and depth limitations that restrict effective surface or daylighted storage, and the prohibitive cost of acquiring private land for detention.

As a result, the Engineering Services department explored the opportunity to coordinate with the Columbia Park renewal project which is part of the Alberta Street Blue-Green System. The work includes a proposed below-ground detention tank beneath the park's proposed synthetic turf field to manage increased rainwater runoff from the Cambie Corridor densification and increasing storm intensities from climate change. The detention tank intends to store and attenuate inflow from the targeted sewer separation along Alberta Street and W 43rd Avenue to defer downstream pipe upgrades, mitigate flooding, and reduce combined sewer overflow (Refer to Appendix C, Figure 6). The detention tank holds a minimum of 1800 cubic metres of rainwater. For such a significant volume, it is not feasible to accommodate it under the road right of way due to the space limitation and underground utility conflict.

The implementation of the detention tank is time-sensitive to meet the timeline of the Phase 2 Alberta Trunk Sewer upgrade, anticipated to begin construction in Q1 of 2027. The proposed upgrades are required to manage peak flows, respond to climate change, support planned growth, and protect water quality, and have been integrated into the park's concept plan.

Refer to Appendix F for a detailed Summary of Engineering Department Analysis & Rationale for the Proposed Detention Tank in Columbia Park.

DISCUSSION

Staff have developed a concept plan guided by feedback received from the public during the engagement process, and meetings with interest groups. The design is also informed by policy and technical and operational requirements.

Park Planning and Engagement Process

Public engagement was undertaken alongside the Alberta Street Blue-Green System engagement process over three phases between 2021 and 2024. Over 300 surveys were submitted, with 5,680 participants viewing materials online and approximately 50 attendees at the 2024 pop-up event.

Across all phases, participants expressed strong support for improving aging amenities, enhancing opportunities for year-round recreation, expanding access to nature, and integrating the park into the broader blue-green network. A small number of participants expressed concerns related to the use of synthetic turf or a preference for natural lawn.

The concept design directly reflects these priorities identified by participants:

- **Recreation and field space:** The concept includes a synthetic turf sport field to support durable, year-round recreation, alongside a large area of open lawn for informal and spontaneous play.

- **Playground renewal:** Improved and inclusive and accessible play experiences including nature play.
- **Circulation and social spaces:** Connected pathways, accessible seating, and passive spaces to support everyday use, socializing, and intergenerational accessibility.
- **Ecology and climate-resilient landscapes:** Ecological connections, rainwater management, increased urban forest canopy and integrating nature into daily park use.

Overall, the proposed concept plan responds to what was heard through engagement by retaining valued park features, addressing long-standing functional issues, and adding amenities that respond directly to community preferences, technical requirements, and long-term policy goals.

For the full engagement summary reports see the project's [Shape Your City](#) page.

PROPOSED CONCEPT PLAN

This project is to be delivered in two phases to manage scope and costs within resource limits. The Columbia Park Concept Plan envisions a multifunctional neighbourhood park that integrates recreation, social spaces, and blue-green rainwater infrastructure. Key elements include a synthetic turf field to replace an existing grass sports field and softball diamond, a renewed playground, accessible pathways and plazas, active and passive open spaces, and a new fenced dog off-leash area. (Refer to Appendix A: Columbia Park Concept Plan).

Columbia Park Phase 1

Phase 1 works are focused on the northern and western areas of the park affected by the detention tank, including replacement of outdated amenities (Refer to Appendix B, Figure 5). Priorities are to maintain and enhance service levels to respond to population growth, leverage cost-sharing and coordination with Engineering, and deliver safe, functional interim conditions that align with the long-term park concept.

Key features of Phase 1 of the concept plan includes the following amenities:

- A synthetic-turf sports field: Located above detention tank – the most compatible surface for this tank, with infrastructure and supports year-round recreation and increased field booking opportunities for field sport users. Includes fenced field area with player benches, field lighting, adjacent warm-up areas, and spectator seating. Staff reviewed the option of reconstructing a natural grass field over the tank. While feasible, it would require over a year of closure, involve higher maintenance, and may be subject to future disruptions and extended closures for tank access. Given the high demand for field use in this rapidly growing area, alignment with the Sport Field Strategy, and the lack of successful regional examples of grass fields over underground structures or rooftops, a synthetic turf field is recommended.
- An all-ages and abilities playground: The new and expanded children's playground will feature various accessible and sensory elements, ensuring an inclusive experience for children of all abilities. Additional trees will provide much-needed shade, and misters are incorporated into the design for cooling and sensory play.
- A standardized washroom (4 single user stalls, 2 of which are accessible) (the existing Portland Loo may be relocated to another park site, after the new washroom is built)
- Site improvements focused on accessible pathways, tree canopy, seating, and related

amenities.

Columbia Park Phase 2

Phase 2 of the concept plan is proposed to include the following amenities:

- A fenced off-leash dog area.
- A large open lawn area to support informal and spontaneous recreation.
- An outdoor fitness area.
- Additional pathway connections and related site improvements identified in the concept plan

The timing for delivery of the second phase has not yet been confirmed and is subject to future funding and prioritization.

FINANCIAL CONSIDERATIONS

The total anticipated project costs for Columbia Park Concept Phase 1 implementation based on a 'Class D' construction estimate including soft costs, project management fees, permitting, and contingencies is \$19M, to be cost shared with Engineering. The Park Board's portion of the cost share is \$9.7M (50%). These costs assume the park's Phase 1 implementation following completion of the detention tank construction in 2028. The cost for the detention tank is not included in this estimate.

Cost estimates for both the capital cost and ongoing operating cost implications will be refined through detailed design. The initial estimate for the Park Operations operating impact of capital for the project is initially estimated at 5% of the construction cost of the project, equating to approximately \$0.44M annually, including a \$0.06M synthetic turf annual operating cost. An increase to the operating budget will be requested for the year of park opening.

Pending Board decision, staff will work with Engineering counterparts to seek cost share funding for the project through the 2027-2030 Capital Plan and subsequent capital budgeting processes. While the project may be eligible for Cambie Corridor Community Amenity Contribution (CAC) funding, the availability of these funds has not yet been confirmed.

Progression of this project to the park's Phase 1 Implementation is dependent on securing funding. The Board will consider indicating a priority for this project alongside several other competing initiatives as part of its deliberations on the 2027–2030 Capital Plan, with final Council decisions anticipated in July 2026.

Phase 2 implementation of the Columbia Park Renewal is anticipated to require an estimated investment of \$5M, and this funding will be considered for prioritization in the 2031-2033 capital planning process.

OTHER CONSIDERATIONS

The proposed detention tank and associated subsurface infrastructure will place some permanent limitations on future park use. Accordingly, Park Board and Engineering staff have worked together to develop a comprehensive concept plan to benefit residents and park users through improved park amenities and innovative underground utilities to reduced reliance on traditional

costly infrastructure and help prevent downstream flooding. A synthetic turf field is well suited for development above the underground structure, and the proposed park renewal cost-sharing arrangement with Engineering provides a considerable community benefit.

There is a critical timing dependency between the park renewal and Engineering Services' required Alberta Street Trunk storm and sanitary sewer separation upgrades to help prevent downstream flooding as sewer separation alone, without local detention, will send larger volumes of flow more quickly to downstream combined sewer areas, increasing flooding risk. Advancing the park concept currently enables integrated design and construction sequencing, minimizes future disruption to the park, and supports timely delivery of critical stormwater infrastructure.

CONCLUSION AND NEXT STEPS

Subject to the Board's decision on the recommendations outlined in this report, detail design for the Columbia Park renewal, funded by the Engineering department, will commence in Q2 2026 through the posting of a public Request for Proposals to assemble a technical design team to complete tender ready contract documents for construction. Construction of the tank and first phase of the park renewal is currently targeted to complete in 2028, subject to funding availability through the 2027 to 2030 Capital Plan and subsequent capital budget processes.

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APPENDIX A

COLUMBIA PARK CONCEPT DESIGN



Figure 1: Site Plan of Columbia Park Concept Design



Figure 2: Columbia Park Perspective Rendering. View from Northwest Entry of “Blue Green Edge”



Figure 3: Columbia Park Perspective Rendering. Passive open space, playground and fitness area.

APPENDIX B

EXISTING PARK AND PHASING APPROACH



Figure 4: Columbia Park, existing conditions and amenities

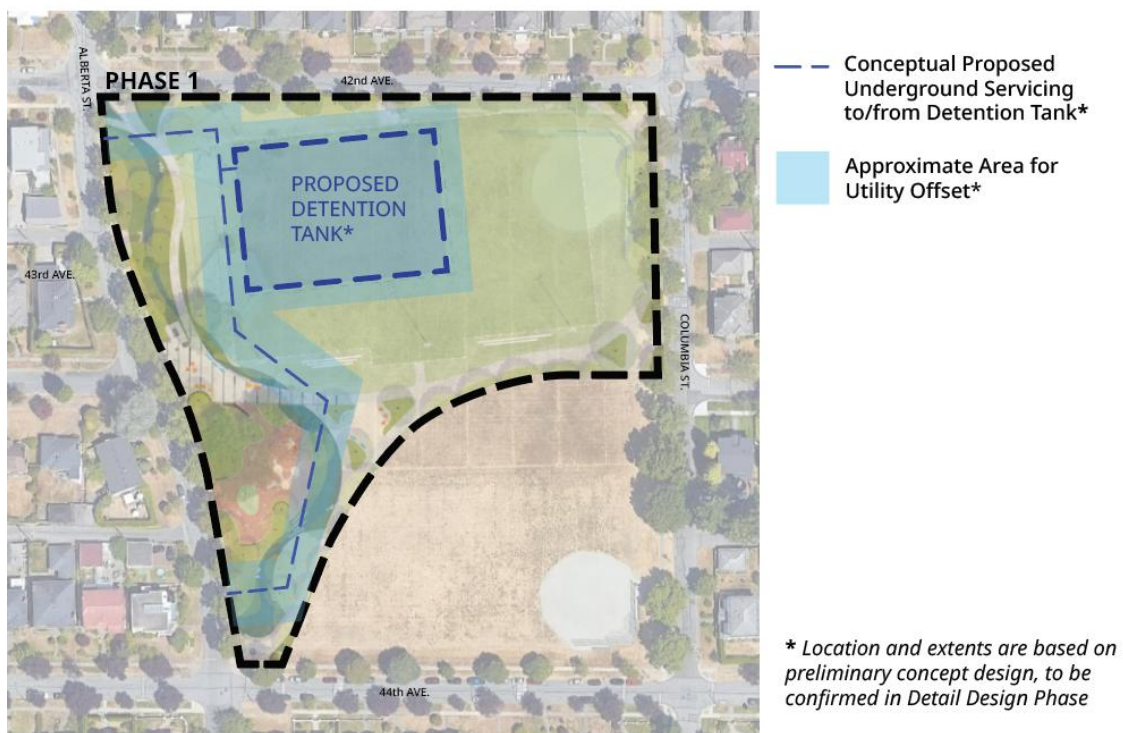


Figure 5: Phase 1 of Columbia Park Renewal

APPENDIX C

SUB-SURFACE RAINWATER MANAGEMENT IN PROJECT AREA

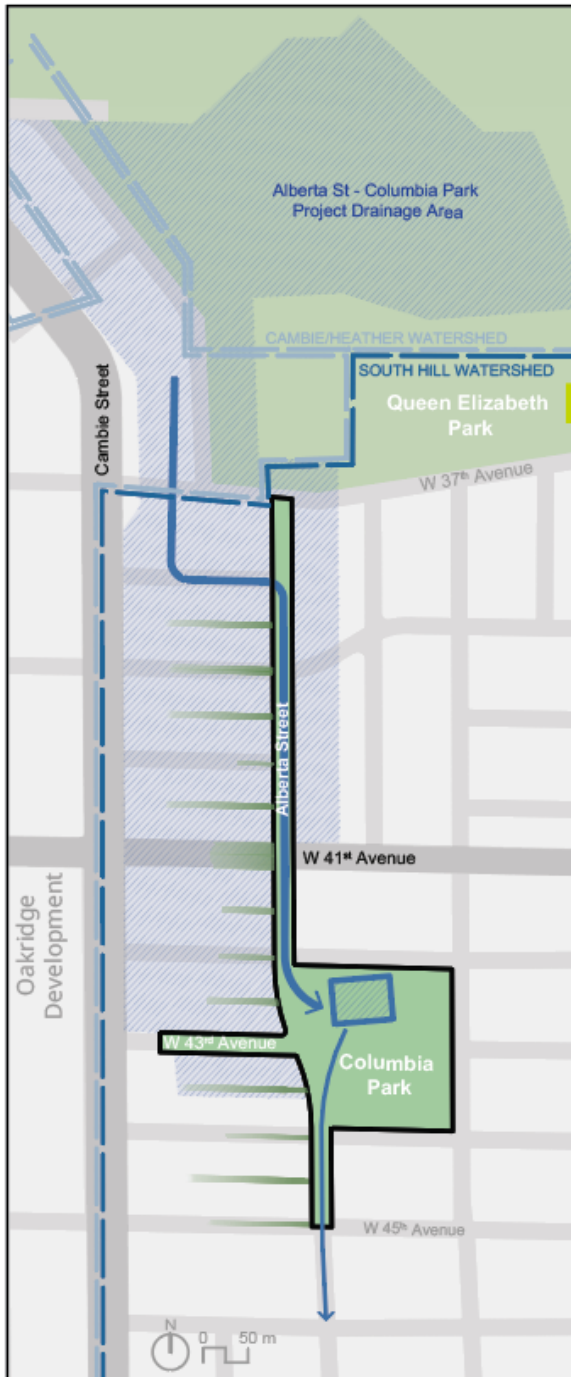


Figure 6 (left): Alberta St & Columbia Park Blue-Green System Subsurface Drainage Plan

Figure 7 (right): Integration of Detention Tank in Columbia Park

APPENDIX D

LITTLE MOUNTAIN TO BIG RIVER CONCEPT (VANPLAY)

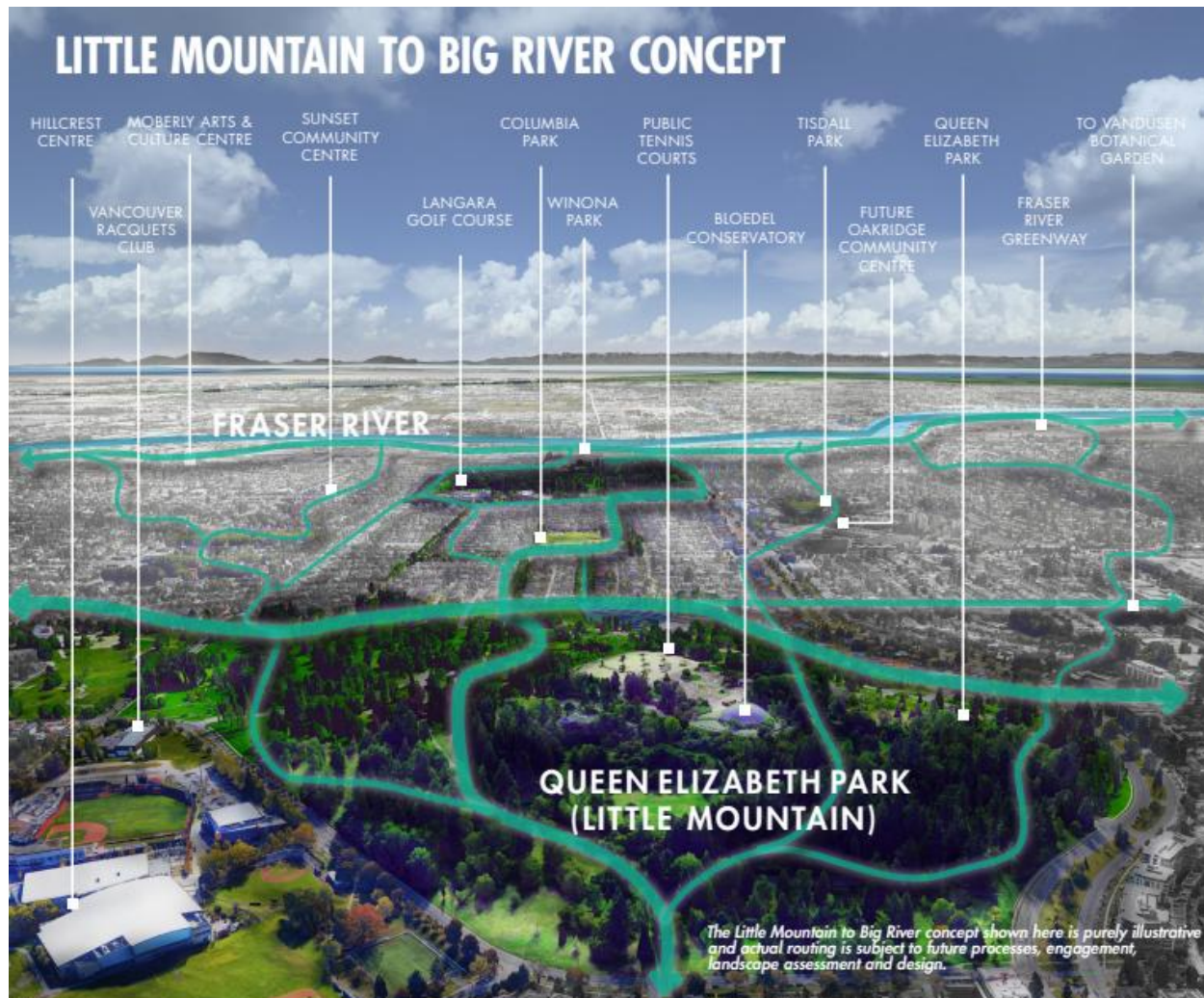


Figure 8: Little Mountain to Big River Concept - VanPlay Strategic Bold Moves Report (2019)

APPENDIX E

PROJECT AREA



Figure 9: Project Area of Alberta Street blue green system and Columbia Park renewal project

APPENDIX F

SUMMARY OF ENGINEERING ANALYSIS & RATIONALE FOR THE PROPOSED DETENTION TANK IN COLUMBIA PARK

Overview & Rationale

Densification is occurring within the Columbia Park catchment area under the Cambie Corridor Plan and Transit-Oriented Development legislation. New development and climate change are increasing sanitary flows and rainwater runoff. To provide adequate drainage service, sewer separation is currently underway along Albert St. However, sewer separation alone, without local detention, will send larger volumes of flow more quickly to downstream combined sewer areas, increasing their flooding risk. Columbia Park presents a unique opportunity to accommodate the required detention facility for the following reasons:

- Columbia Park is located immediately downstream of the development area, but also high enough in the sewershed to have maximum benefit to the downstream sewer capacity.
- Columbia Park is located directly adjacent to the separated sewer along Albert St, allowing it to efficiently receive separated stormwater inflow and release outflow.
- Co-locating the detention system with the proposed synthetic turf field and cost-sharing on the synthetic turf field is a cost-effective solution that benefits park users, housing densification, and the watershed.
- The Columbia Park detention tank project is part of a broader vision: establishing the first segment of the Little Mountain to Big River ecological corridor. The detention tank will help fast-track the renewal of Columbia Park and complements the future Alberta St ecological corridor planned for a later phase.
- The constraint is related to Metro Vancouver's system capacity. And Metro Vancouver has no plans to upgrade its trunk sewer which is constraining flow.

Downstream Drainage Capacity

At its current capacity, the downstream drainage system experiences flooding during a 1-in-5-year storm event. With the projected population densification in the Columbia Park catchment and the implementation of sewer separation, the downstream hydraulic capacity could be reduced to less than a 1-in-2-year level of service.

The proposed detention tank in Columbia Park will help mitigate this increased flooding risk and it will also reduce combined sewer overflows to the Fraser River until the downstream trunks are separated, which is many decades away. The constraint is related to Metro Vancouver's system capacity and Metro Vancouver has no plans to upgrade its trunk sewer which is constraining flow.

Alternatives Analysis

The following five alternatives were assessed by city staff and in external consultant studies:

1. **Downstream pipe upgrades:** Metro Vancouver has no plans to upgrade its trunk sewer which is constraining flow. There are also space constraints that limit pipe size increases for the storm sewer trunk upgrades on Alberta St.
2. **Pipe storage within the ROW:** Alberta St is approximately 8.5 m wide from curb to curb. With a separated sanitary sewer, storm sewer, water main, and other utilities already running underneath, it is not feasible to detain the required rainwater within the remaining sub-surface ROW space.
3. **Storage on the surface of the ROW in blue-green systems:** Modeling by Kerr Wood Leidal found that due to grading constraints, the blue-green system couldn't capture enough runoff to entirely offset the needs for a detention system in the sewershed.
4. **Purchasing Private parcels for detention storage:** Retaining 1,800 m³ of rainwater would require up to six private lots. The BC Assessment market value of six properties in the Columbia Park neighbourhood is approximately \$22 million. With an estimated acquisition premium of about 50%, the total acquisition cost could reach roughly \$33 million, which is considered cost prohibitive.
5. **Daylighting stormwater in a park pond or wetland:** Creus Engineering reviewed the option of creating a naturalized pond or wetland in the park fed by stormwater. Due to the depth of stormwater pipes, 3-5m below ground surface, it would not be feasible to bring the stormwater to the surface without extreme regrading of the park.
6. **Increased stormwater controls on new development:** Stringent detention requirements have been added to the Vancouver Building Bylaw for new development (January 1, 2026). System impacts are yet to be confirmed although given existing system constraints, storage at the park is still recommended in the upper catchment.